

1 **SENATE FLOOR VERSION**

2 February 26, 2025

3 COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE
4 FOR

5 SENATE BILL NO. 212

By: Seifried

6
7 [teacher preparation - TeachForwardOK - proposals -
8 application - approval - grants - funds - reports -
9 response - promulgation of rules - codification -
effective date - emergency]

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12 BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

13 SECTION 1. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
14 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 6-186.1 of Title 70, unless
15 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

16 A. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability
17 shall establish and maintain a two-year pilot program to be known as
18 TeachForwardOK to provide new, high-quality pathways to enter the
19 teaching profession and increase the number of teachers in this
20 state's workforce.

21 B. Within thirty (30) days of the effective date of this act,
22 the Commission shall issue a request for proposals to select
23 technical assistance providers to evaluate teacher education
24 programs in institutions of higher education within The Oklahoma

1 State System of Higher Education that are accredited by the
2 Commission pursuant to Section 6-186 of Title 70 of the Oklahoma
3 Statutes.

4 C. To participate in TeachForwardOK, a teacher education
5 program shall submit an application to the Commission in the manner
6 and on a form prescribed by the Commission. The Commission shall
7 establish criteria to approve applicants. Subject to the
8 availability of funds, the Commission shall award grants to approved
9 applicant teacher education programs. The Commission may use any
10 gifts, grants, devises, and donations from any public or private
11 source and monies appropriated by the Legislature for the purpose of
12 implementing the provisions of this section. Grants shall be used
13 as incentives to participate and to contract with a technical
14 assistance provider selected by the Commission pursuant to
15 subsection B of this section. The provider shall evaluate, at a
16 minimum, the following:

17 1. Teacher candidate recruitment and completion;

18 2. Whether the teacher education program prepares teacher
19 candidates effectively;

20 3. Whether the teacher education program meets workforce needs
21 in this state; and

22 4. Innovative ways to recruit nontraditional teacher candidates
23 unique to the teacher education program.

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1 D. 1. Evaluation reports prepared by a technical assistance
2 provider shall be electronically submitted to the approved applicant
3 teacher education program and the Commission.

4 2. Within ninety (90) days of receiving the report, the teacher
5 education program shall electronically submit a report response to
6 the Commission detailing how the teacher education program plans to
7 address the evaluation report's findings. The report response shall
8 prioritize innovative approaches to provide new, high-quality
9 pathways to enter the teaching profession and increase the number of
10 teachers in this state's workforce including, but not limited to:

11 a. developing a system for recruiting eligible teacher
12 candidates, such as:

13 (1) a pathway for high school students to become
14 paraprofessionals,

15 (2) a pathway for paraprofessionals to become
16 teachers, and

17 (3) a pathway for individuals with bachelor's degrees
18 to become teachers,

19 b. developing a curriculum that includes intensive on-
20 the-job training for teacher candidates,

21 c. identifying a mastery-based evaluation system to
22 determine when eligible teacher candidates have
23 mastered the skills and competencies necessary for
24 graduation from an apprenticeship program and

- 1 outlining benchmarks that teacher candidates must meet
2 as they progress through on-the-job training,
- 3 d. offering a schedule that enables teacher candidates to
4 work full time in a public school district while
5 participating in an apprenticeship program and
6 allowing paraprofessionals to continue in their
7 positions, or
- 8 e. providing a flexible schedule for paraprofessionals
9 participating in an apprenticeship program to support
10 their success in the program that will facilitate
11 course completion and on-the-job training.

12 E. Subject to the availability of funding, the Commission shall
13 review the report responses submitted pursuant to subsection D of
14 this section and select one approved applicant teacher education
15 program to receive Five Hundred Thousand Dollars (\$500,000.00) to
16 enact the initiatives outlined in the program's report response.

17 F. By December 31, 2027, the Commission shall electronically
18 submit a report of TeachForwardOK's findings and recommendations to
19 the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the
20 Speaker of the House of Representatives.

21 G. The Commission shall promulgate rules to implement the
22 provisions of this section.

23 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective July 1, 2025.
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SECTION 3. It being immediately necessary for the preservation of the public peace, health, or safety, an emergency is hereby declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS
February 26, 2025 - DO PASS